

Build e4 before dreaming of e5



KIA-01 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The center pawn is the platform for the attack. Nbd2, Re1 and d3 often support it, but a pin, exchange or different black pawn structure can change the count.

HOW TO DECIDE

Count attackers and legal defenders of e4 after Black's best capture. Only then assess e5 and the knight it would attack. A pawn advance that loses material is not rescued by a familiar plan.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

...dxe4 opens the d-file; ...d4 creates a wedge; ...f6 may undermine an advanced e5. Each demands a different response.

BOARD DRILL

Take three branch positions and list what changes after e5. Include the affected knight, opened diagonal and new pawn weakness.

The e5 wedge and piece routes



KIA-02 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

An e5 pawn can drive Nf6 away and give White space near the king. It also blocks the g2 bishop and becomes a target for ...f6.

HOW TO DECIDE

Prepare useful knight routes, often Nf1-e3 or h2-g4, only when the destination is safe. Bring queen and bishop into play without abandoning d3 and e5.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can counter on the queenside with ...b5 or in the center with ...f6. A beautiful maneuver that arrives too late is ineffective.

BOARD DRILL

Play a closed-center endpoint and require yourself to state Black's next pawn break before every white move.

h4-h5 needs a target



KIA-05 anchor - White to move

THE IDEA

A kingside pawn advance can open lines or gain space when Black has castled short and the center is stable. It is much less persuasive when the king is still central or on the other wing.

HOW TO DECIDE

Identify the pawn contact you intend to create, the piece that will use the opened file and the central reply Black can choose. Count the moves required to reach the target.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black may castle long, exchange on e4 or open with ...f6. Your h-pawn does not defend the center.

BOARD DRILL

At a laboratory checkpoint, compare h4 with a central or developing move. Give a reason connected to the king location.

When c4 is the right adaptation



KIA-08 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

c4 directly questions d5 and often makes sense against an active light-squared bishop or a stable central structure. It may lead to Reti-type play rather than a kingside attack.

HOW TO DECIDE

Calculate ...dxc4 and ...d4 separately. Decide which pawn recaptures and where the queen knight belongs afterward. Keep the g2 bishop's diagonal in view.

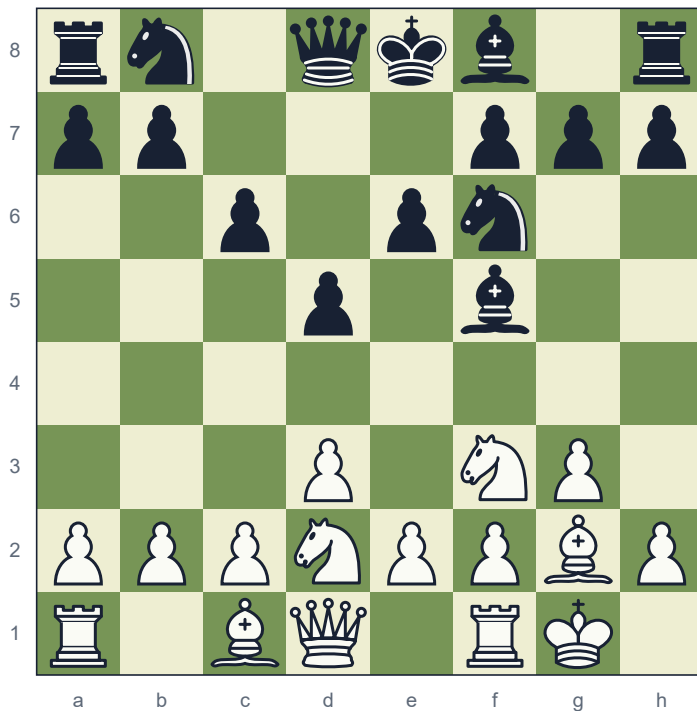
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can close with ...d4 and restrict Nc3. The central challenge must have a follow-up.

BOARD DRILL

Compare one c4 line with one e4 line and explain which pawn file opens in each.

Active bishops change the plan



KIA-07 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

A bishop developed to f5 or g4 before ...e6 is not the restricted French bishop. White may benefit from a central challenge or a useful bishop exchange.

HOW TO DECIDE

If considering Nh4, calculate the bishop retreat and whether h-file exchanges help Black. Compare the value of the bishop pair with the time spent moving the knight twice.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

After Nxg6 hxg6, Black may use the h-file. Doubled pawns do not automatically mean a weak king.

BOARD DRILL

Reconstruct the Nh4 branch and name one benefit for each side after the exchange.

Symmetric fianchettoes



KIA-13 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

With both sides fianchettoed, there may be no ready-made kingside target. Central space, bishop activity and the timing of a pawn break become the main contest.

HOW TO DECIDE

Choose between c3-d4, c4 and e4 based on the current center. Improve the least active piece before manufacturing a wing attack.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can mirror central pressure or seize space with ...d4. White's extra move is useful but does not guarantee an advantage.

BOARD DRILL

Play the same endpoint once with a c-pawn plan and once with a central d-pawn plan. Compare piece squares.

Open-center transitions



KIA-03 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

After ...dxe4 dxe4, the d-file opens and the familiar blocked-center attack may disappear. The bishops and rooks acquire new jobs.

HOW TO DECIDE

Contest the open file, identify an entry square and decide whether exchanging queens helps. A knight on c4 can be useful if it attacks real targets.

THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

Black can pressure e4 and challenge the file. A slow knight tour may concede open-file control.

BOARD DRILL

List the blocked and open lines before and after the central exchange, without using an engine.

Choosing 1.Nf3 or 1.e4



KIA-06 anchor - Black to move

THE IDEA

The main course starts with Nf3 for flexibility. The French and some ...e6 Sicilian routes work well from e4, but Black can choose a different central structure.

HOW TO DECIDE

Match positions by piece locations, pawn structure and side to move. Keep entry routes separate until they truly transpose. Use the branch map when Black occupies e5 or develops an active bishop.

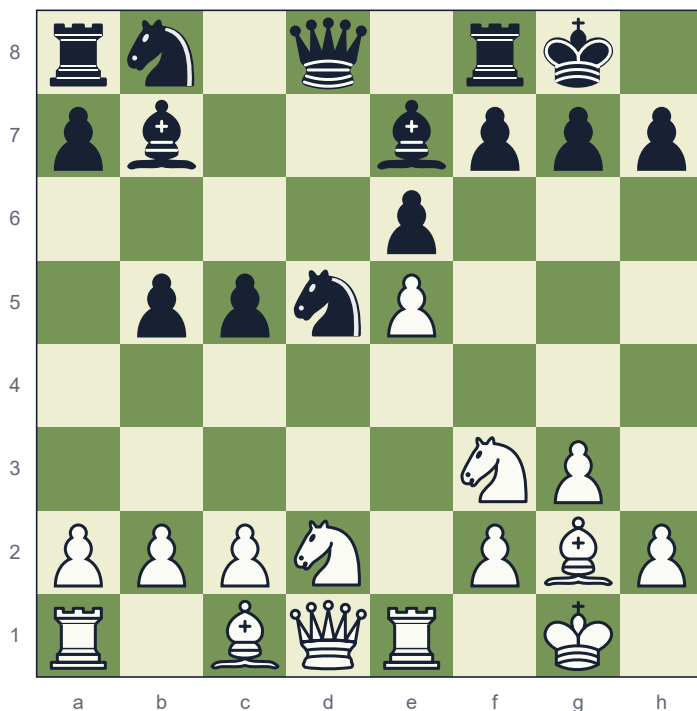
THE OPPONENT'S RESOURCE

A Caro-Kann ...e5 center or a Sicilian fianchetto may offer no French-style e5 attack. Adapt instead of forcing the pattern.

BOARD DRILL

Write two legal routes to the same French-type position, then change one black move and explain why the transposition breaks.

Loose pieces and forks



KIA-03 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Before calculating an attack, list undefended pieces. A knight fork attacks two targets that cannot both move away. A queen check may combine king pressure with a second target. If you remove a defender, inspect every piece it protected.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Find two pieces that would be vulnerable if their defender moved. Calculate one legal forcing move that tests the relation. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

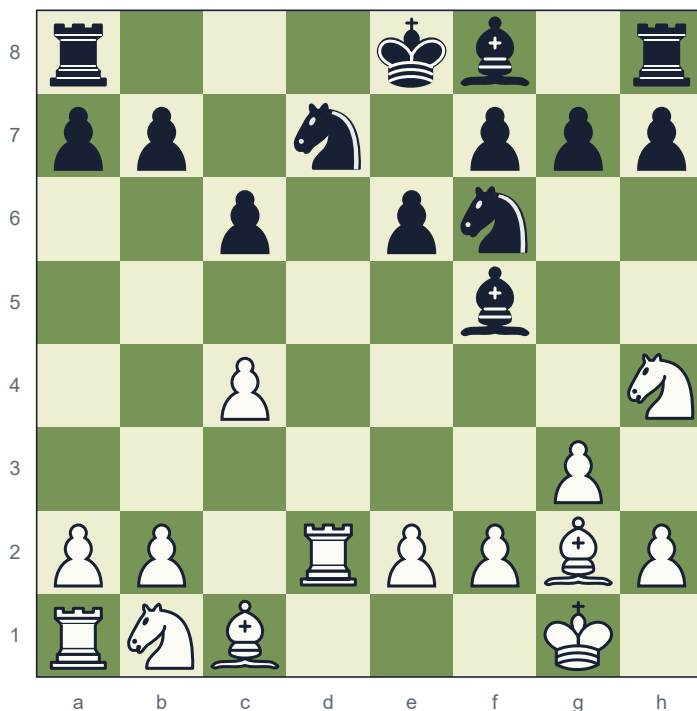
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

An automatic e5 attack plan may no longer fit. Black can use ...Nc6 and ...Qc7 to put pressure on e4.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Pins and discovered attacks



KIA-08 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

An absolute pin prevents a piece from moving if doing so exposes its king. A relative pin involves a valuable piece behind it, usually the queen. A discovered attack appears when a blocking piece moves away. Always trace the entire line, including the piece behind the blocker.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Identify a line piece, its blocker and the target behind it. If no pin exists, explain which required element is missing. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

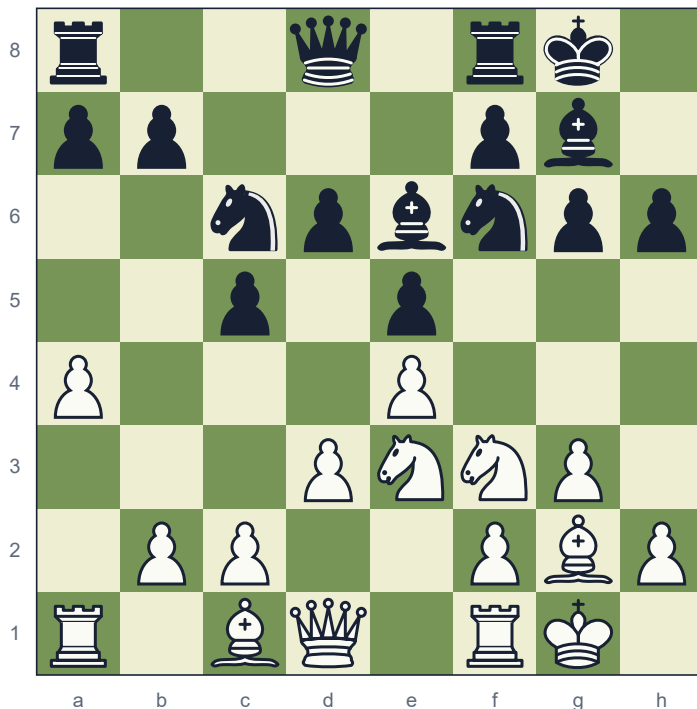
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can exchange queens or use ...Nbd7 and ...Be7 to complete development. The position is now closer to a Reti structure than an e5 attack.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Intermediate moves and defensive resources



KIA-13 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

A recapture is not compulsory unless it is the only legal response to check. Before recapturing, inspect checks, stronger captures and direct threats. When attacking, give the defender the same opportunity; do not assume automatic recaptures.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

At a capture in your line, pause before the reply. List all legal checks, then compare them with the expected recapture. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

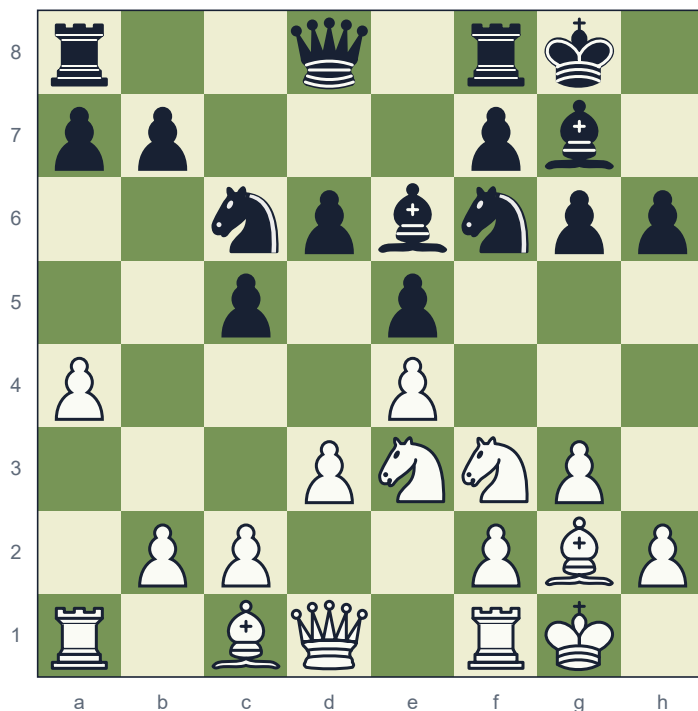
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

An unnecessary e5 can be captured or leave d5 weak. Black can challenge the center with ...c5 just as White can with c4.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

A sacrifice needs a stopping point



KIA-18 audit position - White to move

CALCULATION SKILL

Calculate a sacrifice until the defender has a stable reply you can evaluate. Count material after the whole sequence, not after the first capture. If the line ends only with a vague promise of attack, compare a non-sacrificial candidate.

AUDIT THIS REAL POSITION

Choose a tempting sacrifice from a laboratory or your own game. Write the best defensive reply and the position where you stop calculating. This is an analysis exercise; it does not assert that a winning tactic exists in the diagram.

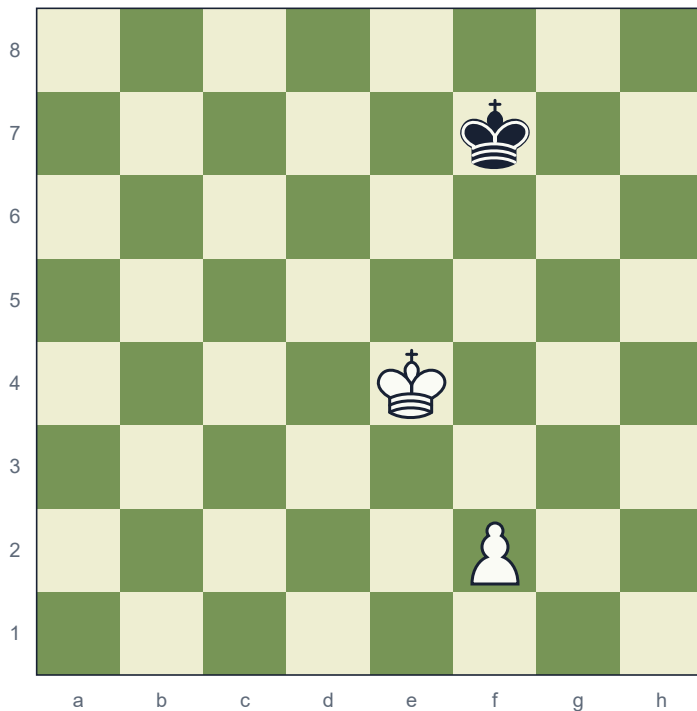
CONNECT IT TO THIS OPENING

Black can play ...Rb8 and ...b5, or ...d5 when ready. Waiting only for an e5 attack can concede the initiative.

A USEFUL ANSWER

Give a short legal variation and an explanation of the resulting material and king safety. If there is no forcing gain, say so and choose a developing or improving move. Finding no combination can be the correct conclusion.

Activate the king when queens are gone



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

White to move: Kf5 is a legal active king move. Kf4 is also legal but less direct; compare plans rather than inventing a forcing win. The general lesson is to bring the king toward the pawn and useful squares while keeping the opposing king out.

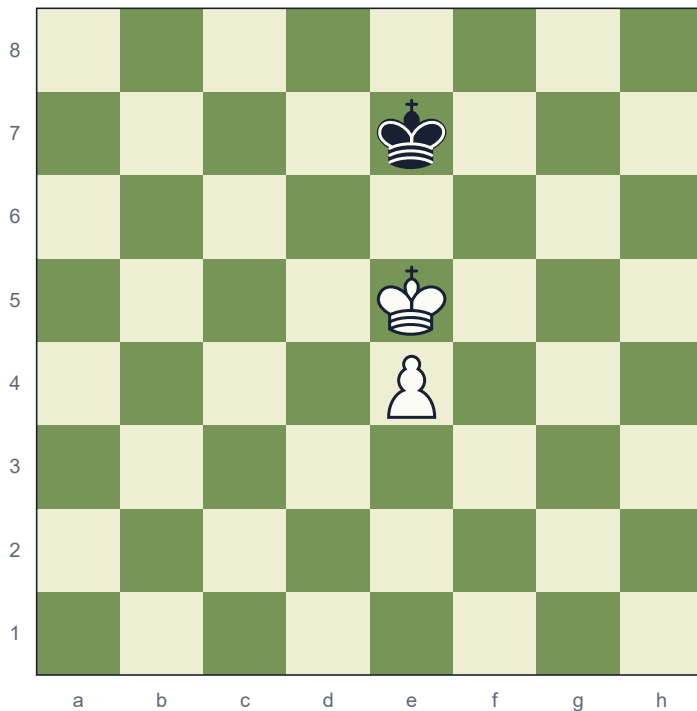
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In an opening-to-endgame transition, first inspect checks and pawn threats, then activate the king. Do not continue making shelter moves whose main purpose was defense against a queen. A rook ending may still require care about checks from behind.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Opposition and the importance of the move



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The kings face each other on e5 and e7 with one square between. White to move must give way or move the pawn; the geometry changes if Black is to move. Opposition is a tool for gaining entry squares, not a rule that always wins.

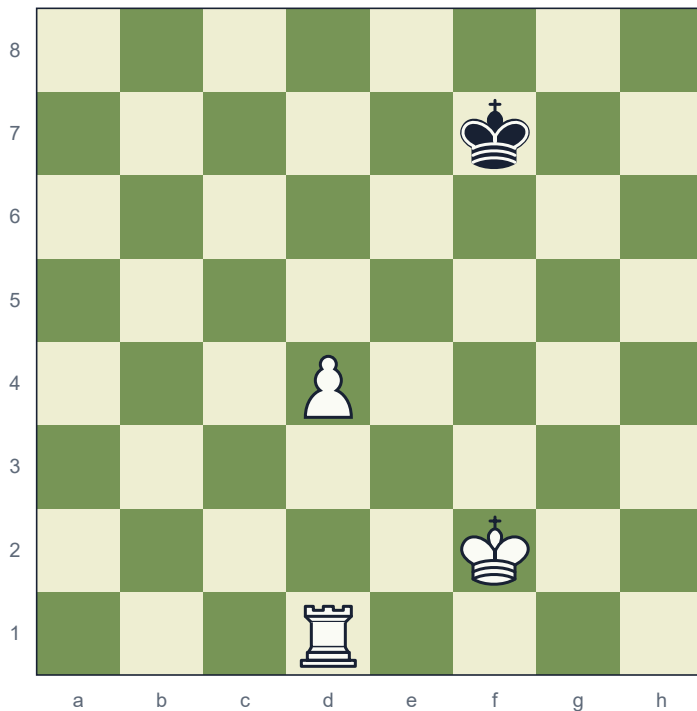
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Replay both side-to-move versions. Track the pawn's key squares and whether the attacking king can reach them. If you exchange into a pawn ending, calculate the actual king route and tempo rather than relying on the extra pawn alone.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Rooks belong where they work



Teaching position - White to move

READ THE BOARD

The rook on d1 stands behind its own passed d-pawn. As the pawn advances, the rook can continue supporting it from behind. This is a teaching position, not a claim of a difficult theoretical win against a rook.

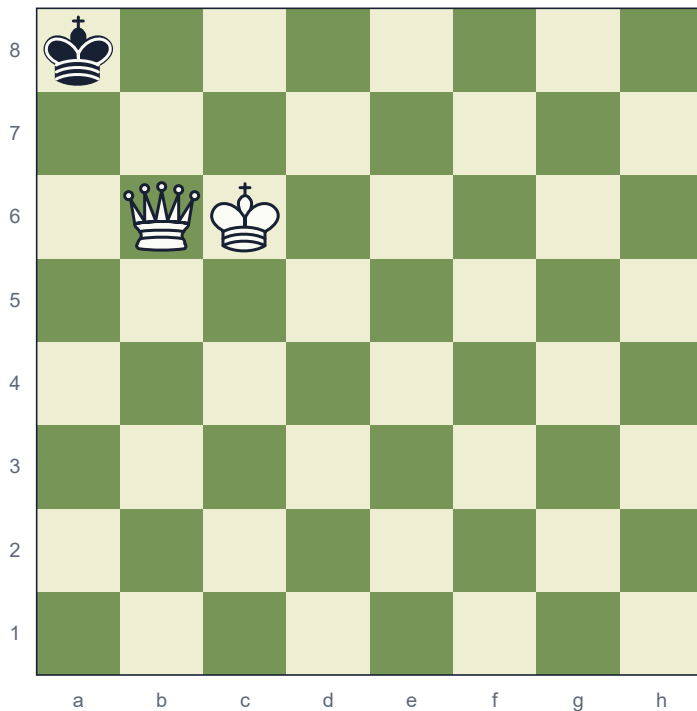
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

In real rook endings compare activity, checking distance, king shelter and pawn races. Putting a rook behind a passed pawn is a useful default, but a tactical threat or a decisive lateral check can override it. Do not trade an active rook into a lost pawn ending.

PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Recognize stalemate before promoting



Teaching position - Black to move

READ THE BOARD

Black to move is not in check and has no legal move: a7 and b8 are controlled by Qb6, while b7 is controlled by the queen and Kc6. This is stalemate, so the position is a draw despite White's extra queen.

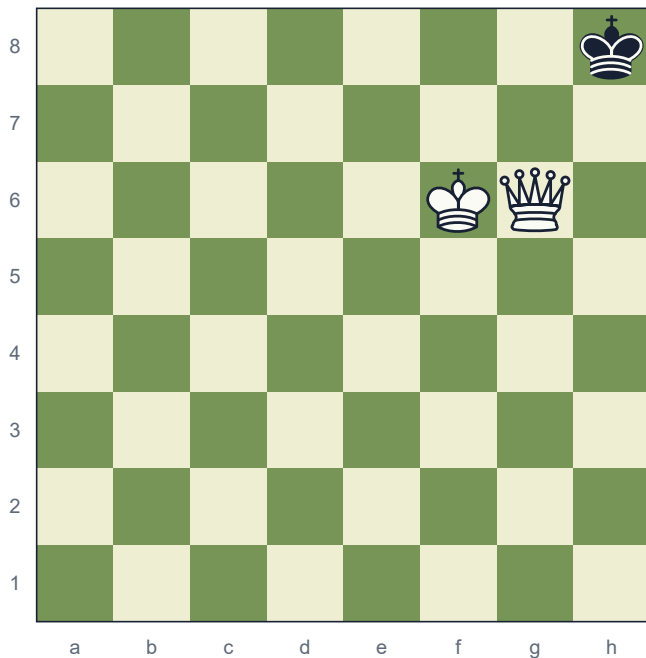
FROM YOUR OPENING TO THIS LESSON

Before delivering the final move of a won game, check whether the opponent has a legal reply if not in check. In queen-versus-king technique, restrict the king with the queen, approach with your king and preserve a legal waiting square until you can give mate.

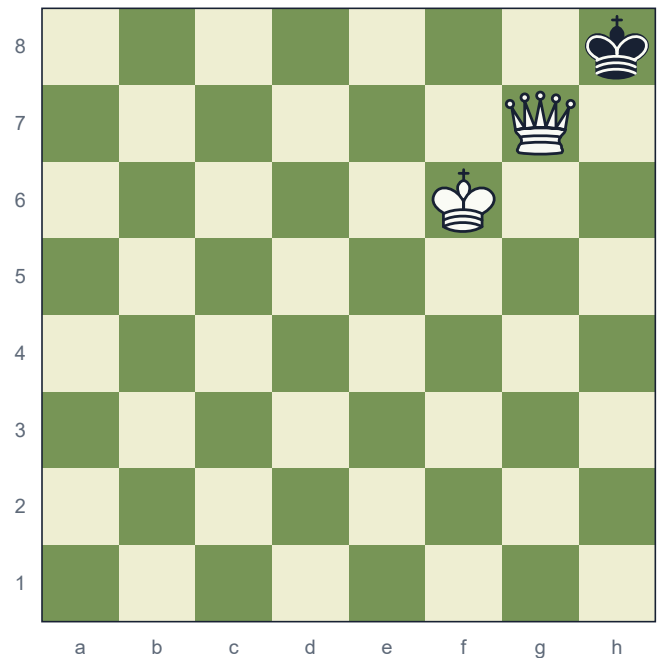
PRACTICE

Reconstruct the diagram. Explain the legal moves and the role of each king before moving. Then return to a course endpoint and identify which feature of this simple lesson could matter after exchanges.

Finish a won queen ending



White to move - find mate in one



After Qg7# - Black is checkmated

WHY THIS IS MATE

Qg7 gives check along the g7-h8 diagonal. The white king on f6 protects the queen, so ...Kxg7 is illegal. The queen controls g8 and h7, removing the remaining escape squares. This proof checks attacks and legal replies, not just the appearance of the diagram.

TECHNIQUE BEFORE THE FINAL MOVE

Use the queen to reduce the enemy king's space, bring your king close enough to support the mate, and keep a legal waiting square until you can give checkmate. A queen alone can accidentally stalemate; review the previous lesson before repeating this drill.

Choosing the right exchanges

DO NOT TRADE BY HABIT

When offered a trade, compare the activity of the pieces leaving the board, the resulting pawn weaknesses and the king positions. A player with less space may welcome exchanges, but trading the only active piece can make the position worse.

PAWN ENDING TEST

Before exchanging the last pieces, calculate king activity, passed-pawn races and the side to move. Opposition is one tool; it is not a substitute for counting legal tempi. A pawn ending is often less forgiving than a rook ending.

OPENING-SPECIFIC QUESTION

The main course starts with Nf3 for flexibility. The French and some ...e6 Sicilian routes work well from e4, but Black can choose a different central structure.

PRACTICAL CONVERSION

When ahead, neutralize counterplay and improve the least active piece before collecting another pawn. When defending, seek active checks, pawn breaks and useful exchanges rather than passive waiting.

A STUDY HABIT

After every practice game, keep one transition position. Record which exchange you chose, which alternative you considered and how the pawn structure changed.